

PCI Express Graphic Cards - High-End**XFX GeForce 7800 GTX 256 MB**

Specs: nVidia GeForce 7800 GTX, 256 MB GDDR3, DirectX 9.0c Compliant, Dual DVI connector, ViVo Capable

Our Verdict: The core of the XFX GeForce 7800 GTX is clocked at 430 MHz. The card features 256 MB of high-speed GDDR3 memory running at 1.25 GHz. It's a card in a class of its own.

It supports DirectX 9.0c—which essentially means Shader Model 3.0—and it's also 100 per cent OpenGL 2.0 compliant. This means gaming on this card will be a veritable feast for your senses—expect lightning-fast performance even in the latest games such as Quake 4 and Call of Duty 2. This card treated the games in our tests like office applications, even with all the eye-candy turned on.

The card sports exotic features such as IntelliSample 4.0, which is an anti-aliasing

technique that improves upon the older technique—IntelliSample 3.0—and yields better-quality anti-aliased textures. There's also UltraShadow II, using which the card renders highly realistic shadows for a fuller 3D experience in games such as *Doom 3*. Then there's HDR—High Dynamic Range—imaging, which is used to render real-world scenes that contain light ranges exceeding the normal dynamic range. This is visible in effects such as realistic glares in games such as *FarCry*.

Of course the XFX GeForce 7800 GTX is expensive. But if you're a hardcore gamer, go get this card right now—this is the best there is!

Runner-Up: MSI NX7800 GTX 256 MB

**HARD DRIVES****Western Digital Caviar SE 250GB WD2500KS**

Specs: 250 GB, SATA II, 16 MB Data Buffer, 7200 rpm Spindle Speed

Our Verdict: The WD2500KS turned out impressive real-world test scores and decent scores in the synthetic tests. Data transfer rates were good, but the drive is tailored for intra-drive transfer performance, thanks to the large data buffer.

Like the any other SATA drive, the WD2500KS has hot-plug support, but the added advantage is the high shock resistance figure. This drive is ideal if you want a capacity as high as 250 GB at an affordable price.

**Hitachi Deskstar 250GB HDT722525DLA380**

Specs: 250 GB, SATA II, 8 MB Data Buffer, 7200 rpm Spindle Speed

Our Verdict: The Hitachi Deskstar 250GB tied with the WD2500KS. The Hitachi Deskstar hard drives are SATA II, but they are shipped as SATA I; to enable SATA II, there's a feature tool utility—a bootable floppy to change the drive settings (if the motherboard supports SATA

II). The good average read and write speeds did translate into good inter-drive transfer speeds. The Hitachi Deskstar 250GB is a performer despite the smaller 8 MB data buffer (as opposed to the 16 MB of the WD2500KS).



Runner-Up: Western Digital Caviar RE2 (400 GB) WD4000YR

Apple 30-inch Cinema HD Display

Apple this year came up with yet another one-of-its-kind product—the Apple 30-inch Cinema HD Display, which has a native resolution of 2560 x 1600, which translates to four million pixels! This top-of-the-line display is also the world's largest desktop screen. Couple it with a framework made of anodised aluminium that feels divine to the touch, and you have a product that's truly awe-inspiring.

There are just three soft-touch buttons along the right-hand side, one for power/sleep, and two for brightness control. The interface to this LCD is via a dual-link DVI connector, so there is no need for

image correction control such as horizontal/vertical position and size. The broad 170-degree viewing angle and the crystal-clear hi-res images should leave you awestruck.

Considering the price, this display seems ideal for multimedia centres and such—it's out of the question for the typical home user.

